

PROPERTY TAX RETURN STATUS CHECKER

New Jersey Innovation Authority | Resident Experience

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Keywords:

metrics, end-to-end testing, accessibility, user research, API development

Summary:

To help New Jersey residents track their property tax relief payments, Nathaniel expanded the Property Tax Return Status Checker to display rebate payments for residents across 3 NJ Property Tax Relief Programs. He shipped both feature updates and DevOps tasks during his time with the Innovation Authority, adding logging, metrics, and end-to-end tests to the website, allowing tens of thousands of residents to view property tax relief payments. He then analyzed resident feedback to identify the most common points of pain and proposed a set of content and interface changes to address them.

PROPERTY TAX RELIEF STATUS CHECKER

Resident Experience Initiative
New Jersey Innovation Authority
John Chan - Software Engineer



BACKGROUND

- New Jersey runs several property tax relief programs (ANCHOR, Senior Freeze, Stay NJ)
 - Different eligibility requirements and income limits
 - Multiple timelines and deadlines to track
 - Difficulty determining which benefits they qualify for and when to apply
- 1,000,000+ applications

OUTGOING SYSTEM

- Outgoing system does not provide a way of understanding next steps or tracking the status of user's application

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 Division of Taxation

Treasury Taxation Taxation Data Security

Property Tax Relief Benefit Status Inquiry

Electronic Services

✓ Application Received

✓ Processing

Approved

Social Security Number (SSN) / Individual Taxpayer Identification Number (ITIN) : ****-**-4022
ZIP Code : 07005
Year : 2025

The Division has received your application. Please allow additional time for processing and review.

If you would like to speak with someone or have questions, call the Property Tax Relief Benefit Hotline at 1-888-238-1233 during regular business hours (Monday through Friday, 8:30 a.m. to 5:30 p.m.). Please have a copy of your application available before calling.

Logout


Equitable, Trustworthy, Compliance

OUTGOING SYSTEM

- Outdated interface design
- Dense, text-heavy pages with small fonts
- Complex instructions that overwhelmed users, primarily Senior Citizens and Social Security/Disability Recipients

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Division of Taxation

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Property Tax Relief Benefit Status Inquiry

Electronic Services

✓ Application Received ✓ Processing ✓ Approved

Social Security Number (SSN) / Individual Taxpayer Identification Number (ITIN) : ****-**-1295
ZIP Code : 08057
Year : 2024

Program	Amount	Status	Refund Type
ANCHOR	\$1,750.00	Issued on 09/15/2025	Check
Senior Freeze (Property Tax Reimbursement)	\$472.05	Issued on 08/01/2025	Check
Stay NJ	\$385.40	Issued on 02/09/2026	Check

Note: All benefit amounts are subject to further review and adjustment.

If your refund type is listed as 'check', expect your benefit payment in the mail. Please allow up to 30 days to receive any checks we send by mail. If you have not received your check after 30 days, you must request that we initiate a check tracer so that we can issue a replacement.

A check tracer is used to research the status of your refund check. After you submit a check tracer, we place a stop payment on the check and find out if the check was cashed.

- If your check was not cashed, we will mail you a new check.
- If your check was not cashed, we will mail you a letter advising it was cashed and instruction if the check was not cashed by you.

If you find the original refund check after you request a tracer you will not be able to cash it because of the stop payment.

You can only use this online tracer request if your current address is the same as the one provided on your 2024 Property Tax Relief Application. If your address is no longer the same, you must submit a written request for a check tracer accompanied by a Change of Address form and copy of a government issued photo ID with your current address listed.

Same Address	Different Address
If you have not received your refund check and the address on your property tax relief application is the same as your current residence, you may request a Check Tracer Allow 8 weeks to receive your replacement refund check or a notice about your refund.	If you have not received your refund check and the address on your property tax application is different from your current residence, you must take the following steps: Submit a written request for a check tracer along with a Change of Address Form and government issued ID showing your current address listed. You can do this by either: Mail New Jersey Division of Taxation PO Box 444 Trenton NJ 08646-0444 Upload Online Notice Response System (ONRS) Select Property Tax Relief to locate PO Box 444

If you would like to speak with someone or have questions, call the Property Tax Relief Benefit Hotline at 1-888-238-1233 during regular business hours (Monday through Friday, 8:30 a.m. to 5:30 p.m.). Please have a copy of your application available before calling.

Note:

Senior Freeze payments are issued first, on a payment schedule, depending on when you apply. The earliest payment will be issued July 15, 2025.

ANCHOR payments will start September 15 and continue on a rolling basis, with most applicants receiving payment within 90 days, unless additional information is required.

Stay NJ payments will be made quarterly beginning in 2026, with payments scheduled for February, May, August, and November. February and May payments are subject to the Fiscal Year 2026 State Budget, and August and November payments are subject to the Fiscal Year 2027 State Budget.

Logout

OUTGOING SYSTEM

Previous Table of Payments:

Program	Amount	Status	Refund Type
ANCHOR	\$1,750.00	Issued on 11/04/2025	Check
Senior Freeze (Property Tax Reimbursement)	\$66.83	Issued on 08/22/2025	Check
Senior Freeze (Property Tax Reimbursement)	\$250.31	Issued on 08/29/2025	Check
Stay NJ	\$209.51	Issued on 02/09/2026	Check

WHAT I BUILT

INITIAL DESIGN



Official Site of the State of New Jersey

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This tool is in beta. This means it is actively being worked on with new features coming soon.

[Log out](#)



Property Tax Relief Status Checker

SSN/ITIN: ****-**-6789 Zip Code: 07199 Tax Year: 2025

Your application was received on 4/14/2025

Your application is being reviewed. No action is needed right now. If you applied early this year, please check back in early summer.

FEATURES

- Expanded API to fetch a resident's full benefit history, including any update payments. Updated frontend in React and Typescript to show all payments a resident has in one table
- Added accessibility improvements confirming the page works with screen readers and keyboard navigation to meet WCAG 2.1



Property Tax Relief Status Checker

SSN/ITIN: ****-**-6789 ZIP Code: 07199 Tax Year: 2025

You are eligible for benefits

To find out when to expect payment on all programs, review the [program payment table](#).

Program	Payment Status	Amount
Senior Freeze	Check sent on [DATE]	\$17.56
Senior Freeze	Your benefit amount was adjusted. Another check was sent on [DATE].	\$377.56

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

When can I expect to receive payments?



FEATURES

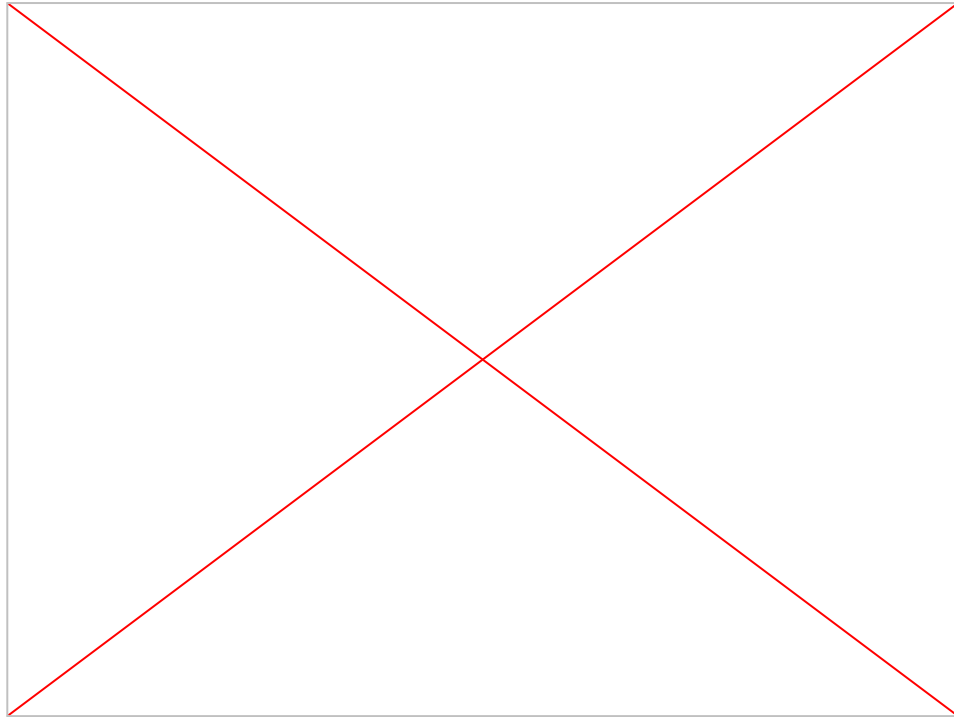
- Implemented metrics through GA4. Team can see how many residents landed on the page, click through FAQs, get a record vs no record found.
- Added feedback widget so team can gather feedback from the public.

TESTING

- Built an automated end-to-end test suite with Cypress
- These tests act like a real resident
 - Open site → enter information → check that right response appears
- Tests run automatically every time anyone changes the code
- Before this every time a deployment was made to the site, Product Manager would have to manually test any changes
 - Team can now ship with confidence for any changes

DEMO

Resident has been sent a
check:



DEMO

Application Received:

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This website is in beta. This means it is actively being worked on with new features coming soon.



Property Tax Relief Status Checker

This website is checking your 2025 PAS-1
application status

Enter your SSN or ITIN and ZIP Code

Social Security or Individual Taxpayer Identification Number *

ZIP code you submitted with your application *

Check Status →

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

When can I expect my application to show up?

+

STRETCH PROJECT

STRETCH PROJECT – BACKGROUND

- A self-directed ticket
- I find a real user problem through user research
- Design and come up with a potential solution
- Go **end to end**, taking a problem from that research through to a shipped feature

STRETCH PROJECT – PROCESS

- Read and categorized resident feedback from the widget
- Grouped questions and comments into recurring themes
 - **Status of application** (35%)
 - Status of check (22%)
 - Payment amount (8%)
 - Timeline of payments (12%)
- Worked with Content and Design team to build recommended solution

STRETCH PROJECT – ENHANCEMENTS

- Future enhancements could include:
 - Better representation of program specific timelines
 - More detail into the process for users
 - Integrating more messages that support Taxation processes

STRETCH PROJECT – PREVIOUS

We received your application on 4/14/2026.

Your application is being reviewed for three property tax relief programs: Senior Freeze, ANCHOR, and Stay NJ. Each program makes payments on different timelines, and not everyone qualifies for all three programs.

- 1 Senior Freeze**
Senior Freeze payments start July 15, 2026.
- 2 ANCHOR**
ANCHOR payments begin September 2026.
- 3 Stay NJ**
Stay NJ quarterly payments begin February 2027.

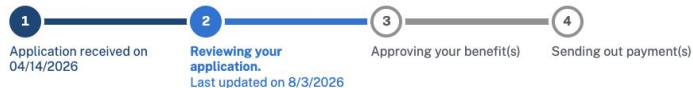
STRETCH PROJECT – RESULTS

Property Tax Relief Status Checker

Log out

Your Application Journey

We are reviewing your application. We have everything we need. You don't need to do anything. Sit tight!



How the payout schedule works:

① Senior Freeze

Senior Freeze payments start July 15, 2026

► [Learn more about Senior Freeze](#)

② ANCHOR

ANCHOR payments begin September 2026

► [Learn more about ANCHOR](#)

① Senior Freeze

Senior Freeze payments start July 15, 2026

▼ [Learn more about Senior Freeze](#)



To qualify for the [Senior Freeze program](#), you (or your spouse) must meet all the below requirements:

- Be 65 years or older on December 31st, 2025 (or receiving Social Security Disability during 2025)
- Have owned and lived in your home since December 31, 2022
- Paid property taxes
- Total annual income for 2025 was \$172,475 or less

REFLECTIONS/LESSONS LEARNED

REFLECTIONS/LESSONS LEARNED

- Automating the tests was the work I enjoyed most, and I feel like it has the biggest impact on other team members working on the project now and in the future
- Reading user feedback reframed an engineering project as a communication problem
 - Content can be a solution

Thank You!

Thank you John, Amy, Emily, Vic, Andrew
and the rest of the NJ Innovation Authority!